



CAMBODIA

Capital city: Phnom Penh
Area: 69,900 sq miles (181,040 sq km)
Population: 14,100,000
Official language: Khmer
Major religions: Buddhist 93%, Muslim 6%, other 1%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Riel
Adult literacy rate: 69%
Life expectancy: 54 years
People per doctor: 3,333
Televisions: 15 per 1,000 people

LAOS

Capital city: Vientiane
Area: 91,428 sq miles (236,800 sq km)
Population: 5,700,000
Official language: Lao
Major religions: Buddhist 85%, other 15%
Government: One-party state
Currency: New kip
Adult literacy rate: 66%
Life expectancy: 56 years
People per doctor: 5,000
Televisions: 4 per 1,000 people

Hmong men often have more than one wife. Each wife is responsible for bringing up her children, and tends her own poultry and vegetable garden.



Angkor Wat consists of a central temple building surrounded by smaller temples and palaces and huge moats and reservoirs.



ANGKOR WAT

For centuries the vast temple complex of Angkor Wat lay hidden in the jungles of northern Cambodia. It was built in the 12th century by the Khmer King Suryavarman II, in honor of the Hindu god Vishnu, and was once the center of a huge empire. When the Khmers fell from power, Angkor Wat was abandoned, and the jungle gradually grew over the buildings. The site has been uncovered in the last 100 years.



CLASSICAL DANCE

In the temple of Angkor Wat, royal dancers performed religious dances based on the Indian epic tales of the Ramayana and the Mahabharata. This type of classical dance is highly stylized, with graceful movements requiring years of training to perfect. The dancers wear richly embroidered costumes so tight that they have to be sewn into them before each performance.

THE WORLD'S BIGGEST MINEFIELD

The lengthy wars in Cambodia have left the country in a desperate state. The road and rail systems have collapsed, and industry barely exists. Up to 3 million mines are thought to lie buried in the ground. Despite the efforts of mine clearers, like the man in this picture, many mines are discovered only when someone steps on one. As a result, some 20,000 people have been disabled.

LAOS

LAOS IS A COMMUNIST STATE and one of the poorest and most isolated countries in the world. Three-quarters of its people are farmers; many of them grow only enough food to feed their families. Aside from the fertile Mekong Valley, the land is rugged and unsuitable for farming. Yet Laos is rich in gold and other minerals, and also produces lumber and coffee.

THE HILL PEOPLES

Peoples such as these Hmong have lived in the isolated hill areas of Laos for many years. They grow corn and rice to eat, and opium poppies to sell. But this traditional way of life has been badly affected by the wars in this region and many Hmong have left the country and settled in Thailand or the US.



THE FRIENDSHIP BRIDGE

Spanning the Mekong River near the capital city of Vientiane is the Friendship Bridge, which opened in 1994. Laos is landlocked (it has no coastline), and the bridge provides the only direct route to Thailand and its seaports.

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